

operational freedom to the Vigilance Department. We have also taken steps like hiring retired CBI officials to strengthen the bureau. We have ensured that the corrupt are no longer treated with kid gloves. They are now a scared lot in Bihar. We may not say that corruption has completely been eradicated. But we know that they have changed their methodology to receive bribes. Let me tell you, however, the government is breathing down their neck."

The Government's stand should come as an assurance to people because despite increased raids and trap cases, the vigilance officials have failed to net even a single gazetted official from government departments labelled 'lucrative'—urban development, mining and geology, water resources, tourism, excise and, food and civil supply. The success rate of the Vigilance Bureau against officials in government wings like transport and health is abysmally low. Neelmani agrees, "The arrests of officials should not be taken as an indicator of corruption in departments to which they belong. Similarly, nobody can say that departments where not a single trap case has been executed are clean. Our functioning depends on the feedback we receive. But, we are aware that we need to be pro-active."

The Vigilance Bureau has also pushed for other options to step up the heat against corrupt officials. Earlier officials managed to 'evade' departmental proceedings because protocol stated that these should be initiated only after the court disposed off cases against them. Neelmani adds: "The Bureau, however, obtained a legal opinion which clarified that departmental proceedings should not wait for the court's verdict." Verma periodically meets department heads to ensure initiation of departmental proceedings right after an official has been caught taking a bribe. Verma adds: "Once a chargesheet is lodged, officials caught taking a bribe must be suspended."

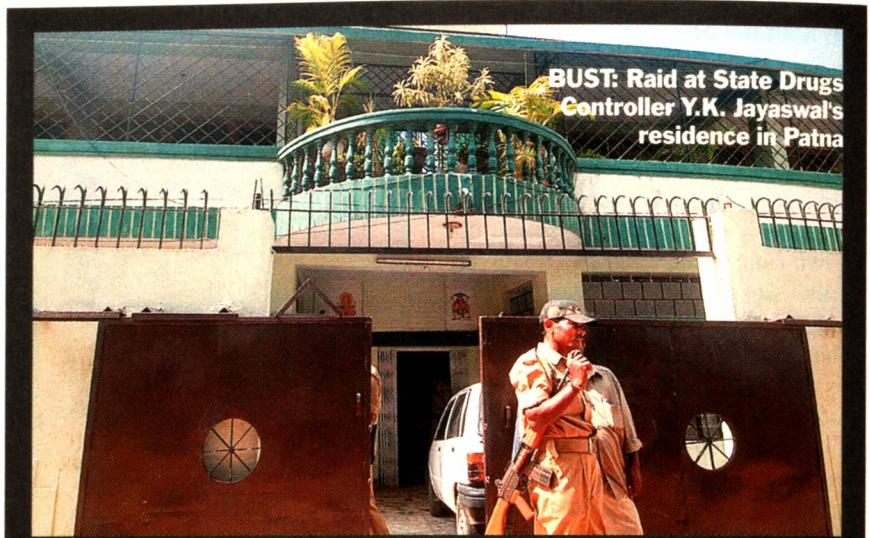
Recent raids prove that corruption has deep roots. Last month, engineer Surendra Prasad was caught allegedly accepting Rs 10,000 and sexual favours from a woman, whom he had

called to a hotel room at night. In addition to the bribe money, pornographic material was recovered from him. In another case, the Vigilance Bureau raided the residences of former DGP, Bihar, Narayan Mishra and his relatives at Patna and Hazaribagh, Jharkhand, and recovered cash and investment papers worth over Rs 8 lakh besides evidence that pointed to "illegal earnings". A disproportionate assets case was lodged against Mishra, an IPS officer of the 1969 batch who had been the state police chief from November 2004 to May 2005. This was incidentally the first operation conducted by Corruption Linked Efforts for Affirmative Action which was set up in November last year to intensify the campaign against corruption among government officials.

Similarly, on October 13, 2006, the then Madhepura district magistrate, Hemchandra Jha, was arrested allegedly carrying bribe money.

Sources say the tip-off against Jha came from none other than Chief Minister Nitish Kumar. In July this year the Bureau made its most startling seizure when it recovered over 9 kg gold, including a 1 kg gold brick, 800 gold coins, and more than 1 kg silver from the bank locker of former Minor Irrigation Secretary S.S. Verma, who is now under suspension. A case has also been lodged against him for allegedly amassing assets more than his known sources of income. The latest swoop unearthed evidence of assets worth Rs 2 crore from the residences of the acting drug controller, Y.K. Jaiswal.

The Government's numerous efforts in stemming the rot in the system seem to be yielding results with the number of raids shooting up phenomenally. But the drive will be considered a real success only when the cases stand up the legal drill and the accused are sentenced. Till then it will be a wait and watch game.



GRAFT GRAPH

YEAR	CASES	RAIDS	TRAP CASES IN DEPARTMENTS
2001	19	5	HRD—18
2003	29	3	Revenue—14
2005	22	8	Home (Police)—13
2006	114	60 (68 arrested)	Personnel Department—10
2007	118	93 (109 arrested)	Gazetted Officials Involved—54

DOWN AND OUT

S.S. VERMA: Minor Irrigation Secretary. Disproportionate assets case filed.

HEMCHANDRA JHA: District Magistrate. Caught with Rs 1.75 lakh cash.

SADHU YADAV: RJD MP. Chargesheeted in disproportionate assets case.

BACHANESWAR JHA: Assistant, DRDA. Arrested with Rs 35,000. Rs 9 lakh seized.

PURSHOTAM MISHRA: Assistant Engineer. Arrested taking Rs 1.28 lakh bribe.